watch your interests. We live by the rules and you have my word I will always trust you with my life,' Mathur said.

'We are fighting for a cause, for our own nation. What makes you believe that I will abandon my friends?' Chatar asked.

'You are abandoning enemies and gaining friends in return,' Mathur said.

It took another hour for Mathur to persuade Chatar that he would be doing a great favour to his family by defecting. Just before he finished the psy op, Mathur walked to Chatar's chair and pulled out an envelope from his jacket. It contained ten thousand freshly minted dollar bills. Chatar quietly placed it on the side table.

'Come and see me on Christmas/ Chatar said, avoiding eye contact with Mathur.

Back in the safe house, Mathur began poring over his Punjab files and the dossier of agents who were his eyes and ears. As a spy, Mathur had recruited many smugglers, murderers and gangsters after meticulously checking their psychological behaviour. These antisocial elements or 'pure criminals' as Mathur called them, were regarded as the best operatives in the field; Mathur always said that outlaws were best suited to covert operations. In the USA, he applied the same tactic with utmost secrecy to sanitise the insurgents' den back home. 'They are temperamental but genuine, they are full of impurities but with the potential of gold, they are misguided but questing. If you make the right connection and play them right, they could be the best informers and saboteurs you needed,' Mathur once said.